

TrustMRR: The Trophy Case That Reads Like an Obituary

Narrative spine: TrustMRR exists to make indie-hacker revenue *credible*. Read all 1,000 verified rows at once, and the most credible thing the platform proves is that the median builder never makes it. The deck earns the right to that claim slide by slide, then closes with the only defensible way to play.

Dataset: 1,000 startups, TrustMRR, 30 July 2026. Revenue is API-verified through connected payment providers, not self-reported.



A Platform Built to Prove Indie Hacking Works

\$334,043,738

All-time verified revenue across 1,000 indie startups

Verified, Not Claimed

TrustMRR verifies revenue by connecting directly to the founder's payment provider. No screenshots, no claims.

The Most Honest Dataset

That single design choice makes this the most honest dataset in indie hacking.

Uncomfortable Numbers

It is also why the numbers are so uncomfortable.

"TrustMRR was built as a trophy case. Founders plug in their Stripe key and the platform publishes what they actually earn. I pulled all 1,000 rows to answer a simple question — what does building your own product really pay? The answer is not the one the platform is selling."

Eleven Companies Own Half of It

\$282

Median monthly recurring revenue. The mean is \$13,472.

Top 11 Apps

50% of all revenue earned last month. Top 100 = 84%.

216 Apps (22%)

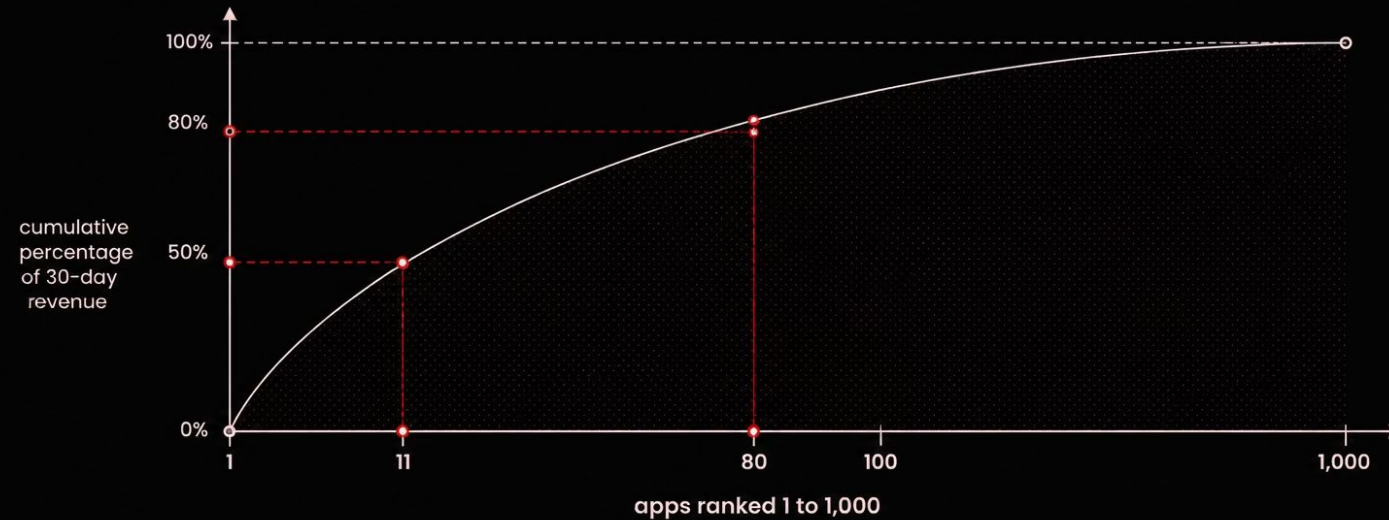
Earned nothing at all in the last 30 days.

Bottom 500 Apps

Combined, produced 0.2% of last month's revenue.

98 Apps

Earned money once and have since gone silent.



TrustMRR only lists apps that connected a payment provider. Every failure rate here is understated — the true denominator is far larger.

"Whenever someone quotes an average in this space, they are quoting the eleven. The median builder makes two hundred and eighty-two dollars a month. That is not a business. That is a phone bill."

The Crowded Categories Are the Poorest Ones

197

AI Builders

27% of everyone, median MRR \$446

\$2,142

Education

30 builders, median MRR \$2,142

\$42

Productivity

49 builders, median MRR \$42, only 12% ever cross \$1k

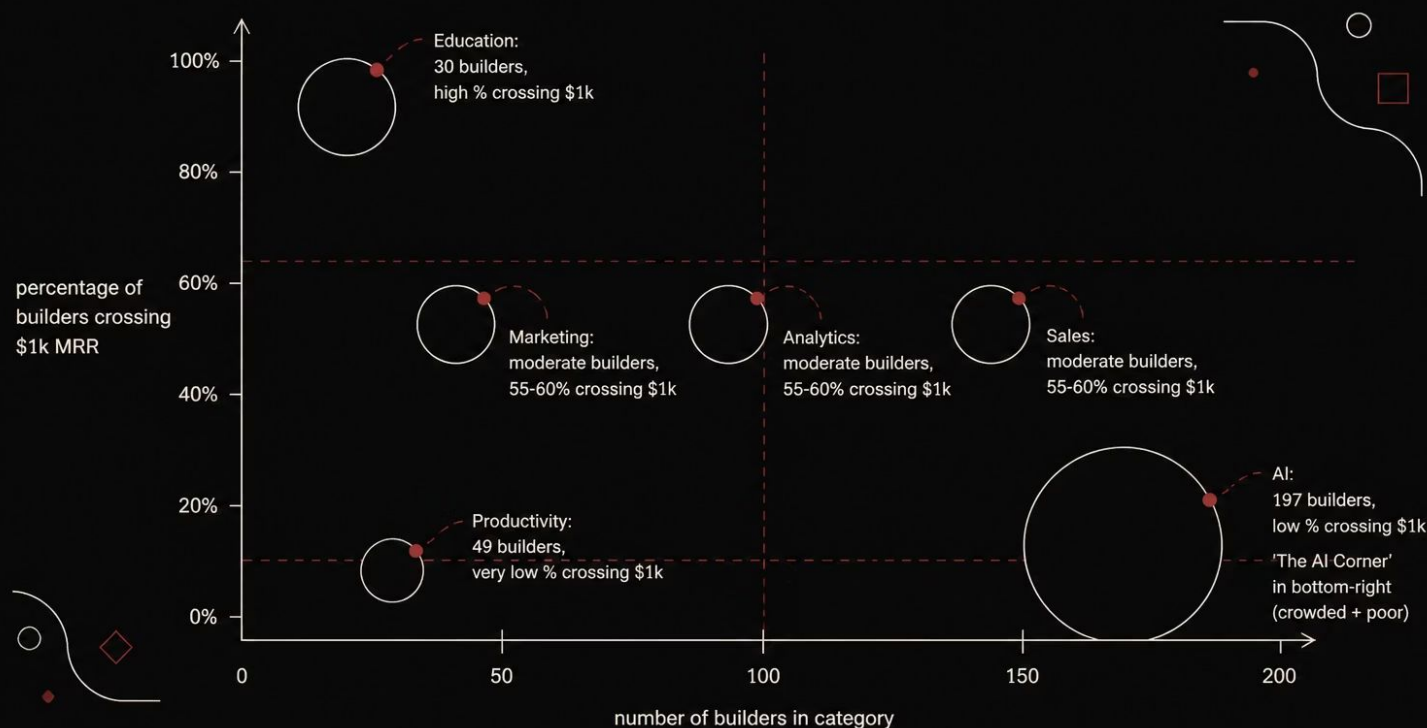
The Best-Paying Categories

The best-paying categories are the unglamorous ones: Education, Marketing, Analytics, Sales — 55–60% of builders in each cross \$1,000 MRR.

AI & Productivity

AI attracts more than a quarter of all builders and returns 15% of the revenue.

Productivity is the trap quadrant: high build appeal, near-zero willingness to pay.



"There is an inverse relationship between how exciting a category sounds and how much it pays. The people making money are selling to marketers and teachers, not building agents."

One Rail, Two Playbooks, One Expensive Mistake

64%

Stripe

64% of apps, 87% of all revenue

19%

RevenueCat

19% of apps, 96% of them B2C mobile

5.7x

B2B vs B2C Gap

B2B median MRR \$1,036 vs B2C \$181 — a 5.7x gap

The Payment Rail

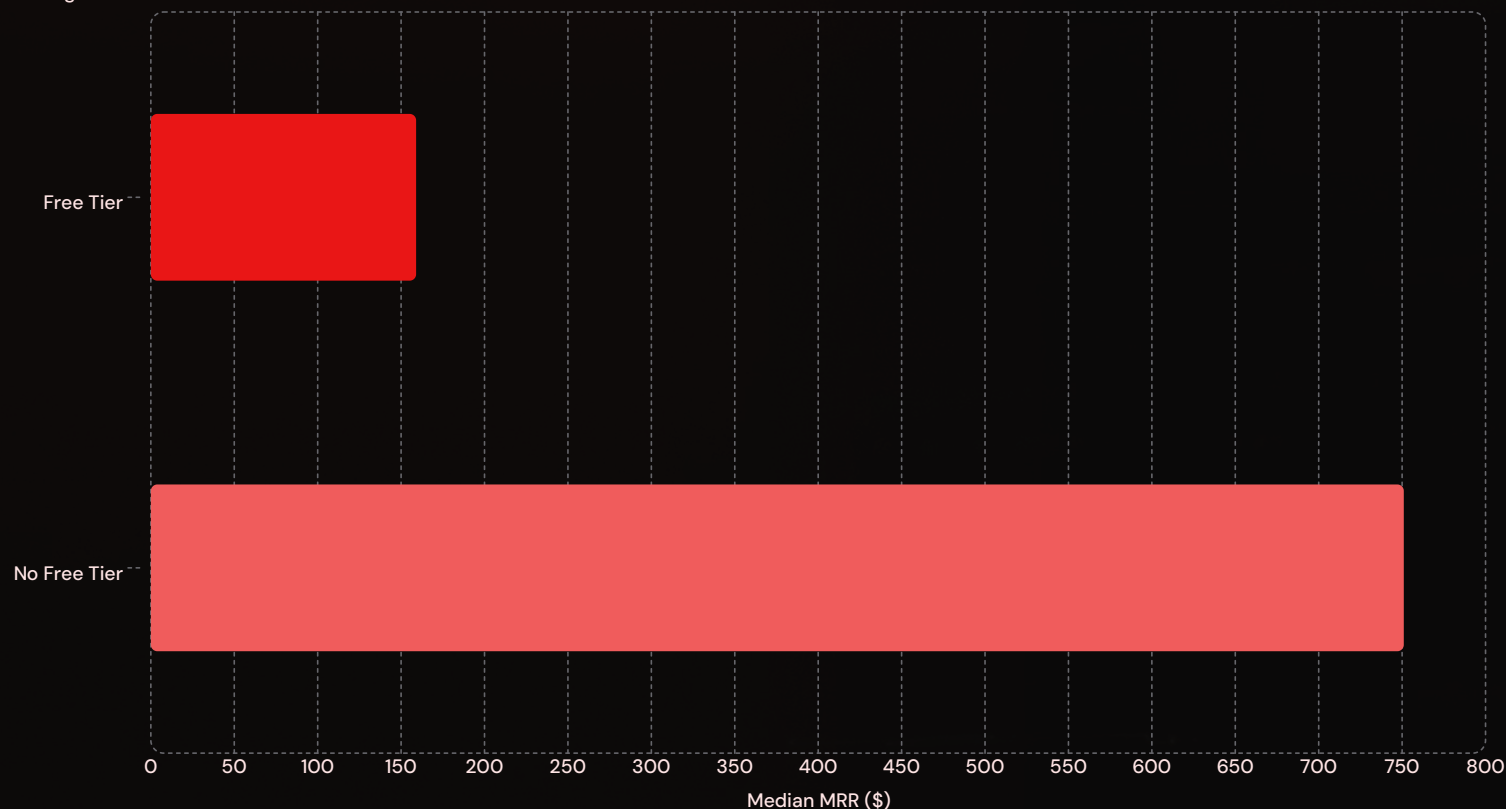
The payment rail is a settled question. Stripe by default; RevenueCat only if you ship on the App Store. Everything else is a rounding error.

The Pricing Architecture

The pricing *architecture* is where the money is won or lost:

- Apps with **no free tier** post a median MRR of **\$751**. Apps with a free tier: **\$159**.
- The median advertised price point across the platform is just **\$29/month**.

Pricing Tier



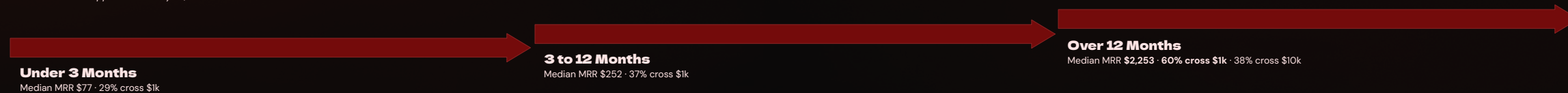
□ "That free-tier gap is correlation, not proof — B2B tools charge from day one and also sell to richer buyers. But the direction is consistent across every category I cut."

"Nobody loses because they chose the wrong payment provider. They lose because they gave the product away and hoped."

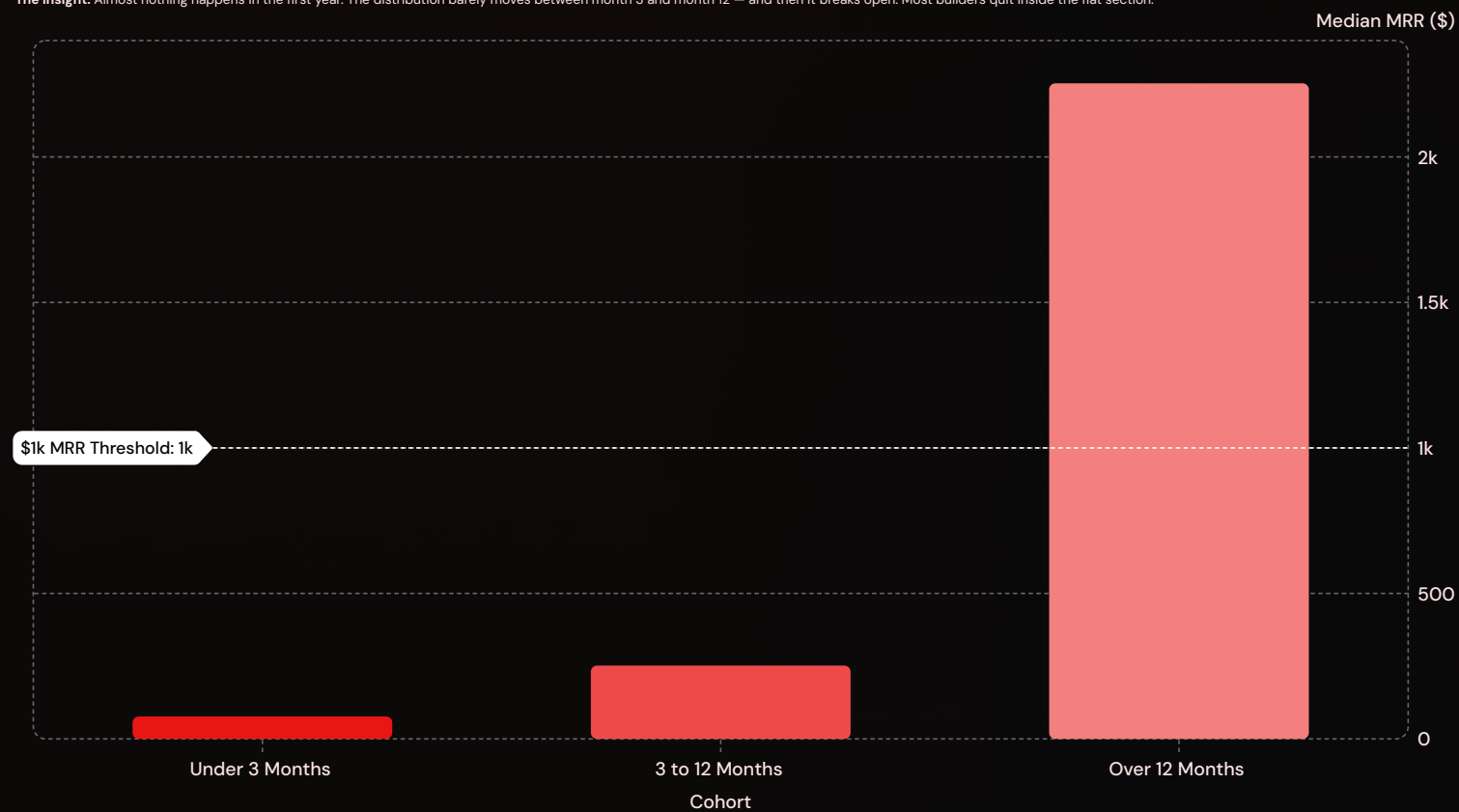
The Twelve-Month Wall

29x

Median MRR of an app older than a year, versus one under three months



The insight: Almost nothing happens in the first year. The distribution barely moves between month 3 and month 12 — and then it breaks open. Most builders quit inside the flat section.



Age inferred from where all-time revenue equals the 3-month or 12-month window — the dataset has no launch date.

"This is the slide I would put in front of anyone about to start. Year one is not a ramp, it is a plateau. The compounding is real, but it is backloaded, and the survival cost is paid up front."

Build an Audience, or Build a Moat?

Domain Rating → MRR

0.49

X Followers → MRR

0.17

(Spearman rank correlation)

Search authority is roughly three times the signal that social following is.

DR 30+

Apps with a domain rating of 30+ post a median MRR of **\$6,739**; 75% cross \$1k.

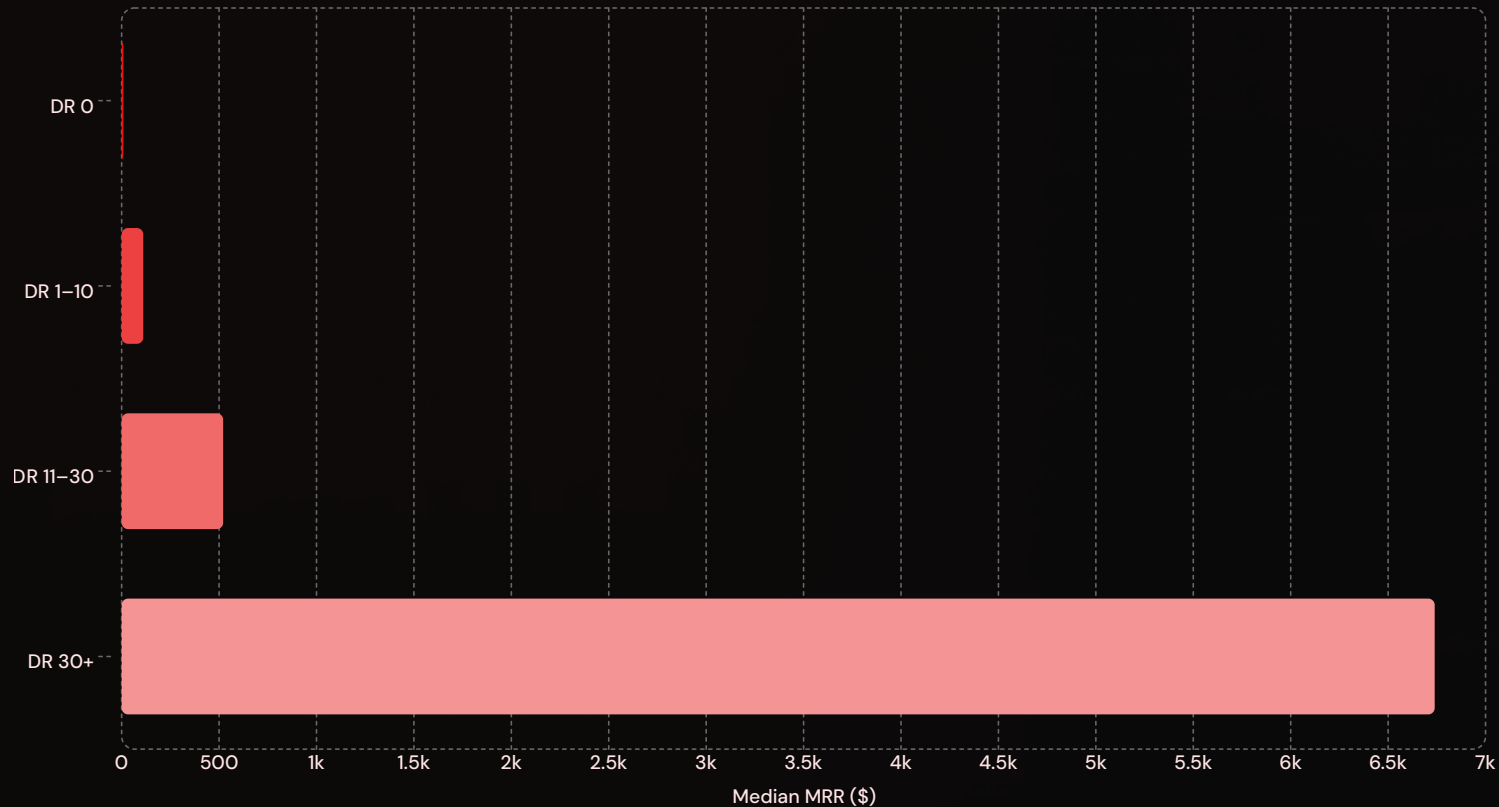
DR Zero

The 22% of apps with a domain rating of zero post a median MRR of **\$9**.

Stealth & No Website

13% of founders on the platform list themselves as "Stealth Company" and 14% have no live website — they want the credibility badge without the exposure.

Domain Rating



"Build in public is the loudest advice in this community and the weakest predictor in this data. The apps that earn are the ones people can find when they are already looking for a solution."

The Odds Are Worse Than the Pitch. Play Anyway – But Play It as a Portfolio.

\$35,000

Median asking price of the 262 apps currently for sale — 2.3x annual revenue

The contrarian verdict, in three lines:

1 The median outcome is failure, and the platform's own data says so.
\$282 MRR, 22% earning nothing, eleven apps holding half the revenue.

2 A win is smaller than it looks.
The typical successful exit here trades for about \$35,000 — roughly a quarter of one engineer-year.

3 Therefore the only rational structure is a portfolio, not a bet.
Any single app is a lottery ticket. Six to eight tickets, played with rules, is a strategy.

The rules the data supports:

- Sell to businesses, or to consumers you can reach through search
- Charge from day one — no free tier
- Stripe by default; RevenueCat only for mobile
- Invest in domain authority before audience
- Set a 12-month clock, not a 90-day one
- Kill rule: domain rating under 10 and MRR under \$250 by month nine

"TrustMRR set out to prove that indie revenue is real. It succeeded. What it also proved, without meaning to, is how rarely it is *enough* — and that is the more useful finding."

Appendix – Data Notes

Dataset

n = 1,000 · TrustMRR · 30 July 2026 · revenue API-verified via connected payment providers

Survivorship Bias

Listing requires a connected payment provider, so apps that never monetised are systematically absent

Missing Data

Category 27%, country 24%, pricing model 34%, website 14%

Derived Fields

Age cohorts inferred from revenue-window equality; no launch date exists in the source

Concentration

Concentration measured on 30-day revenue; all-time revenue is more concentrated still (top 10 = 61%)

Correlations

Correlations are Spearman rank, appropriate for this distribution — Pearson would be dominated by the eleven outliers